

Introduction

“... with the war, the epidemic, and the weather, times are altogether troublesome.”

This quote is not from our era, but from a letter written by a 15-year-old using the name Christabel to a newspaper in New Zealand in 1919, shortly after the end of the First World War and in the midst of a deadly influenza epidemic.¹ It is a reminder of the enduring nature of the challenges that humans face, of the way that global events can affect childhoods, and of children’s engagement in public debate.

Christabel would probably agree that children of the 2020s are also growing up in “troublesome” times. Long-standing problems like conflict and pandemics are now merging with new threats posed by rapid climate change.

The world’s wealthiest countries are not immune to these challenges. When the COVID-19 pandemic was declared in March 2020, Italy was one of the first epicentres. Subsequently, hundreds of millions of people across the globe were confined to their homes, and schools were often closed for long periods.

Armed conflict continues to directly and indirectly affect children worldwide. Many countries – poor and rich – have received influxes of children and families fleeing conflict.

And while climate events disproportionately affect poor countries, the growing environmental crisis does not respect borders. In 2022, more than a quarter of a million children in high-income countries were displaced within their country because of natural disasters such as floods and wildfires,² while periods of extreme heat affected many more children.³

Along with these ‘three Cs’ – COVID, conflict and climate – childhoods are being transformed by the ‘two Ds’ – digital technology and demographic change. This raises essential questions about children’s well-being: